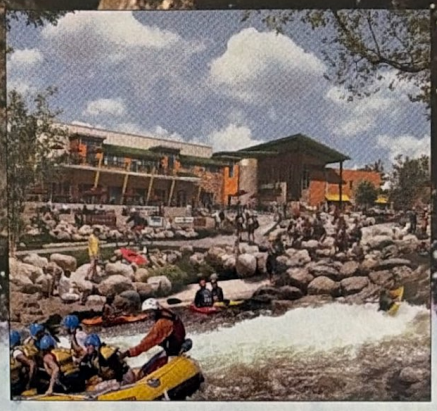
Weekend Warrior

EE DAYS AND COUNTING...

RIP-ROARING RAPIDS!

A slippery rundown of the baddest paddle lands around.

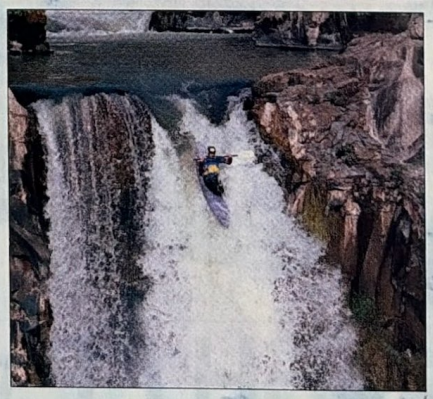
THE PARKS



Think of whitewater parks as kayaker-friendly playgrounds where you won't get beat up for your lunch money. Why? Because bullies hate getting wet, and these carefully diverted (or straight-up artificial) rivers are made for adventurous boaters who aren't afraid of swallowing a little water. Here you'll find steady rapids, swirling holes and well-formed waves—perfect for cartwheeling rodeo kayakers and noodle-armed novices alike.

- **TRUCKEE RIVER WHITEWATER PARK, Reno, Nevada**
- **CLEAR CREEK WHITEWATER PARK, Golden, Colorado**
- **U.S. NATIONAL WHITEWATER CENTER, Charlotte, North Carolina**

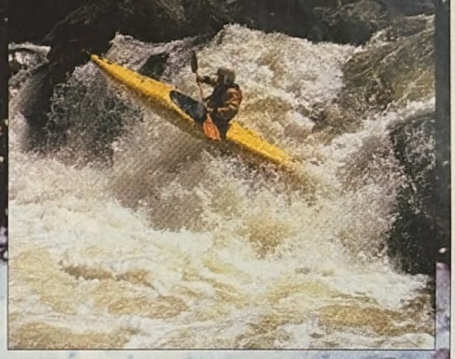
THE RIVER WILD



Whitewater intensity ranges from mellow Class 1 ripples to meat-grinding Class 6 rapids, and anything over a Class 4 requires cojones so big they'll barely fit in a kayak. This is where you can choose your poison: trickling waterfalls that jettison you into space or surging liquid avalanches that eat you alive. In either case, be sure to scope out your safe zones and protected eddies before taking the plunge—Old Man River can be a righteous asshole when he's upset.

- **GORILLA FALLS ON THE GREEN RIVER, Asheville, North Carolina**
- **NORTH FORK ON THE PAYETTE RIVER, Boise, Idaho**
- **CHERRY BOMB FALLS ON CHERRY CREEK, Fresno, California**

THE PLAYSPOTS

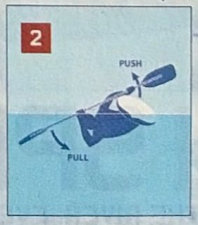


Naturally occurring whitewater features are often called playspots, and they can be anything from stacked waves to churning holes. You can paddle these watery wonders for hours, which is especially nice if you're not up to running a lengthy river section (or if you're very lazy). Local boaters covet their favorite playspots like surfers do their top-secret breaks, so unless you want a swift paddle across the thorax, it's wise to play nice.

- **SKOOKUMCHUCK RAPIDS, near Vancouver Island, British Columbia, Canada**
- **GOLD'S HOLE ON THE SALMON RIVER, Riggins, Idaho**
- **THE DIAGONAL LEDGES ON THE GAULEY RIVER, Glen Jean, West Virginia**

HOW TO UNFLIP YOUR BOAT

1 "OH, NO, I'M F-ED!"
Rather than abandoning ship, lean forward and twist your body so as to position the paddle alongside your kayak. Hold it slightly above the water and keep the front blade as flat as possible.



2 "IF I CAN JUST..."
Sweep the blade across the surface of the water until your paddle is nearly perpendicular to the boat, and pull it underwater, keeping the broad face downward for maximum catch. Push the opposite blade up and out.

3 "SWEET, SWEET OXYGEN!"
Keep a low body profile as your kayak rights itself. Snap your hips to finish off the move—your head should be the last thing out of the water. Gasp for air and swear off smoking forever.

GET WET!
Want to show off your river-running prowess? Log on to stuffviptravel.com, and check out the kayaking trips we've lined up. Book your badass vacation today!